

The Widow's Handbook - Printable Checklists and Worksheets

From *The Widow's Handbook* by Anne Merriweather (Oro Enigma Publishing). Print as many copies as you need.

The First-Year Checklist, by Month

The first week

	Done
Funeral home chosen; he has been collected	
Ten to fifteen certified death certificates ordered; certificate checked for errors	
Family told; someone appointed to answer the phone	
Will found (original kept safe); lawyer's office told	
Prepaid funeral plan, letter of wishes, DD-214 found if they exist	
Funeral decisions made from the itemized price list; nothing bought that was not wanted	
Obituary written without the home address or the service time out of the house	
House occupied during the service; papers and valuables locked up	
His phone kept charged and on; passcode found	
Joint funds needed for the next weeks moved to your own account	

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Nothing paid that you are unsure of; nothing signed except the funeral papers	
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The first month

	Done
Social Security notified; survivor benefits discussed; month-of-death payment returned	
Employer or pension plan notified; survivor pension confirmed in writing	
Every life insurance policy claimed (employer group life included); lump sum taken	
Banks and brokerages: sole accounts frozen, joint retitled, POD/TOD transferred	
Retirement accounts: beneficiary claim started; NOT cashed out	
Medicare and health insurer updated; Medigap told	
Mortgage servicer notified in writing; recognized as successor; payments continuing	
Homeowner's and car insurance in your name	

DMV: his license; car title plan	
Credit cards: sole cards closed to the estate; a card in your own name applied for	
Credit bureaus: "deceased" flag on his file; fraud alert on yours	
VA notified if he served	
Utilities, phone, subscriptions, memberships, voter registration, passport	
One notebook of every call: date, name, reference, what was said	
Mail boxed unopened-until-batch; nothing thrown away	
Your own doctor's appointment booked	

Months two and three

	Done
Inventory of assets, income and debts completed with date-of-death values (Appendix C)	
Estate: lawyer met; probate or small-estate route chosen; letters obtained if needed	

Creditors referred to the executor in writing; nothing of his paid from your money	
Social Security: the four numbers obtained; claiming plan chosen; claim filed	
Retirement accounts rolled over or kept as inherited, with advice; his final RMD taken if due	
Pension survivor payments started; annuity contracts checked	
Health insurance settled (Medicare premium billing; COBRA or marketplace if under 65)	
Extra Help / Medicare Savings Program checked; SSA-44 filed if IRMAA applied	
Budget worksheet completed from three months of statements	
Lump sums parked in an insured account	
Family meeting held; ask list written	
Grief group or bereavement program found (hospice, GriefShare, community)	

Months four to six

	Done
Portability election (Form 706) decided with the accountant; deadline nine months from death	
Estate income tax return (Form 1041) if the estate earned over \$600	
Title to the house corrected; property tax exemptions reapplied for	
Car retitled or sold	
His email and social media memorialized or closed after downloading photos and contacts	
His clothes and things: begun, in your own time	
Fee-only adviser met, if wanted; nothing signed at the first meeting	
The calendar of firsts planned	

Months seven to twelve

	Done
Final joint tax return filed (by April 15 of the following year);	

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CPA consulted	
Estate closed, or on schedule	
Beneficiary audit done on every account of yours (Appendix C)	
Your will, power of attorney, health care proxy and living will redone	
Your folder made; two people told where it is	
Decision about the house reviewed with a year's real numbers; two-year sale window noted	
House adapted for one person; medical alert if living alone	
A weekly place where you are expected	
The anniversary planned	

Who to Notify

Who	Why	What they need	When
Social Security (1-800-772-1213)	Report death; return month-of-death payment; survivor benefits; \$255	His SSN, date of death; later the certificates for the claim	Week 1-2
His employer (HR)	Final pay, vacation, group life, 401(k), health coverage for you	Death certificate	Week 1-2
Pension plan(s) / PBGC	Survivor annuity	Death certificate, marriage certificate, your ID	Week 1-2
Life insurers (all)	Claims	Claim form, death certificate, policy number	Week 1-3
Banks, credit unions	Freeze sole accounts; retitle joint; pay POD	Death certificate, ID; letters testamentary for sole accounts	Week 2-4
Brokerages, mutual funds	Same; date-of-death	Same	Week 2-4

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	values; TOD transfers		
Retirement account custodians	Beneficiary claim; rollover or inherited IRA	Death certificate, beneficiary form, your ID	Week 2-8
Annuity companies	Death benefit or spousal continuation	Death certificate, contract	Month 1-2
Medicare (1-800-633-4227)	Premium billing; your coverage	Your Medicare number	Month 1
Medigap / Part D / Advantage insurers	Household discount; premium payment	Policy numbers	Month 1
Mortgage servicer	Successor in interest; continue loan	Death certificate, deed or probate papers	Month 1
Homeowner's and auto insurers	Policies in your name	Death certificate	Month 1
DMV	Driver's license; car title	Death certificate, title, probate or small-estate papers	Month 1-3
Credit card companies	Close sole cards; continue joint; own card	Death certificate	Month 1

Equifax, Experian, TransUnion	"Deceased" flag; fraud alert on your file	Death certificate, his SSN	Month 1
VA (1-800-827-1000)	Burial benefits; DIC; Survivors Pension; CHAMPVA	DD-214, death certificate, marriage certificate	Month 1
IRS / state revenue	Final return; estate EIN; Form 706 if electing portability	Death certificate with returns	By the filing deadlines
Utilities, phone, internet, cable	Into your name	Account numbers	Month 1-2
Subscriptions, memberships, clubs	Cancel or transfer		Month 1-3
Post office	Mail continuity (do not forward away from yourself)		Month 1
Passport agency, voter registrar, professional licensing boards	Cancel	Death certificate copy or letter	Month 1-3
Lawyer, accountant,	The estate, the taxes, the	The inventory	Month 1-2

financial adviser	plan		
Email and social media companies	Memorialize or close	Death certificate, proof of relationship, or legacy contact	Month 6+
Doctor, dentist, pharmacy	His records; your own appointments		Month 1-2
Landlord (if renting)	Lease in your name	Death certificate	Month 1
Places of worship, charities he gave to, alumni associations	Stop his mailings; memorial gifts		Any time

C1 - The inventory

Asset / account	Institution and contact	Whose name (his / joint / mine / trust)	Beneficiary named?	Value at date of death	Action and date

Debt	Creditor and contact	Whose name	Balance	Secured on	Estate's or mine?

C2 - Social Security: the four numbers

	Amount
My own retirement benefit at 62	
My own benefit at my full retirement age	
My own benefit at 70	
Survivor benefit at 60	
Survivor benefit at my survivor full retirement age	
The larger long-run benefit is: (own at 70 / survivor at FRA)	
Plan: take _____ first at age ____; switch to _____ at age ____	
Am I working? Expected earnings against the \$24,480 limit	
\$255 lump sum applied for on	
Claim filed on; first payment expected	

C3 - The income that continues

Source	Before (monthly)	After (monthly)	Notes
His Social Security		stops	
My Social Security / survivor benefit			
His pension		survivor %	
My pension			
Wages (his / mine)			
Annuities			
Investment and interest income			
Rent, other			
DIC / other survivor payments			
Total			

C4 - The budget

Expense	Monthly before	Monthly now	Notes
Mortgage or rent			
Property tax, HOA			
Home insurance, maintenance, yard			
Utilities, phone, internet			
Food			
Car: loan, insurance, fuel, maintenance			
Medicare premiums, Medigap, Part D			
Medicines and medical			
Other insurance (life, LTC)			
Income taxes (estimated, single)			

Help in the house, services he did			
Gifts, travel, subscriptions, personal			
Total			
Income (C3) minus expenses			

C5 - Questions for the estate lawyer

Question	Answer
What must go through probate, and what passes outside it?	
Does the small-estate procedure apply?	
Your fee: percentage or hourly, and an estimate	
Timeline, and the creditors' claim window	
Should we file Form 706 for portability?	
Any state estate or inheritance tax?	
What should I not sign, sell or transfer until you say?	
The house title: what needs recording?	
The retirement accounts: any issue with the beneficiary designation?	
Is there anything in the will that needs explaining?	

C6 - Questions for the financial adviser or CPA

Question	Answer
How are you paid? (fee-only / commission / both) Are you a fiduciary?	
Final joint return and the estate's returns: what is needed?	
Portability, stepped-up basis: what do we do?	
Retirement accounts: roll over, or keep inherited? RMD due this year?	
Withdrawal plan for the next three years that keeps me under the IRMAA thresholds	
Should I file SSA-44?	
The house: sell within two years or stay? Tax effect	
Where should the lump sums sit for the first year?	
What income can I count on, and for how long?	
What should I not do this year?	

C7 - The ask list

Task	Who I could ask	Asked on	Done
The notification calls (Appendix B)			
Come with me to the lawyer / adviser / Social Security			
Sort the tools / the garage / the collection			
The yard, the gutters, the furnace service			
Sunday lunch every other week			
A call on Wednesday evenings			
Drive me to (appointment)			
Help with his clothes, when I am ready			

Set up the computer / phone / passwords			

C8 - The family meeting agenda

Item	Notes / decisions
What the money looks like, in outline	
What I have decided for this year (the house, nothing big)	
What I would like from each of you (the ask list)	
How his things will be shared: each person's one or two requests	
The calendar of firsts: who will be where	
The folder, and who knows where it is	
Next meeting	

C9 - The beneficiary audit (my accounts)

Account	Institution	Current beneficiary	New primary	New contingent	Form sent	Confirmed
IRA						
401(k) / 403(b) / TSP						
Roth IRA						
Life insurance						
Annuity						
Bank accounts (add POD)						
Brokerage (add TOD)						
House (TOD deed or trust?)						

C10 - My own papers

Document	Done / where	Who has copies
Will (new executor named)		
Durable power of attorney (new agent)		
Health care proxy / power of attorney		
Living will / POLST		
The inventory of my accounts		
Insurance policies		
Deed, car title		
Funeral wishes, prepaid plan		
Password manager master password (sealed)		
Letter to my children		
Two people who know where the folder is		

C11 - The calendar of firsts

First	Date	Plan (who, where, what)	How it went
His birthday			
My birthday			
Our anniversary			
Thanksgiving			
Christmas / Hanukkah / other			
New Year			
Mother's Day / Father's Day			
Our vacation			
The anniversary of the death			

C12 - Scam call card

- Did I start this contact? If not, I hang up.
- Nothing by gift card, wire, crypto or courier. Nothing decided on the phone.
- "I'll think about it and call you back on a number I find myself."
- "I don't decide anything without my daughter / son / friend."
- His debts are the estate's; refer to the executor in writing.
- Report: reportfraud.ftc.gov; 1-877-808-2468 (Senior Medicare Patrol).